

DRAMATIC ELEMENTS IN THE POETRY OF ROBERT FROST : A CRITICAL STUDY

RESEARCH PROJECT

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**“Everything written is as good as it is
dramatic. It need not declare itself in
form but it is drama or nothing.”**

Robert frost: Preface to A Way Out

CHAPTER I : INTRODUCTION

ROBEHYRT FROST : BIOGRAPHY

Personal life

Robert Frost married Elinor White in 1895, after attending high school together in Lawrence, Massachusetts. They had six children together: Elliott, Lesley, Carol, Irma, Marjorie, and Elinor Bettina. Frost and Elinor faced numerous challenges throughout their marriage, including financial difficulties and the deaths of two of their children. Despite these hardships, their marriage endured, and Elinor played a significant role in supporting Frost's career as a poet. She provided feedback on his work and managed the household while he focused on his writing. Their marriage lasted until Elinor's death in 1938, after which Frost remarried to his secretary, Kathleen Morrison.

Frost's personal life was plagued by grief and loss. In 1885, when he was 11, his father died of tuberculosis, leaving the family with just eight dollars. Frost's mother died of cancer in 1900. In 1920, he had to commit his younger sister Jeanie to a mental hospital, where she died nine years later. Mental illness apparently ran in Frost's family, as both he and his mother suffered from depression, and his daughter Irma was committed to a mental hospital in 1947. Frost's wife, Elinor, also experienced bouts of depression.

Elinor and Robert Frost had six children: son Elliott (1896–1900, died of cholera); daughter Lesley Frost Ballantine (1899–1983); son Carol (1902–1940); daughter Irma (1903–1967); daughter Marjorie (1905–1934, died as a result of puerperal fever after childbirth); and daughter Elinor Bettina (died just one day after her birth in 1907). Only Lesley and Irma outlived their father. Frost's wife, who had heart problems throughout her life, developed breast cancer in 1937 and died of heart

failure in 1938.

Frost's Work

Robert Frost's body of work is extensive and includes numerous poems that have become classics of American literature. Some of his most notable and widely studied poems include:

"The Road Not Taken" - Perhaps Frost's most famous poem, it explores the idea of choice and the paths we take in life.

"Stopping by Woods on a Snowy Evening" - A meditative poem that delves into themes of nature, solitude, and the passage of time.

"Mending Wall" - This poem reflects on the nature of boundaries, both physical and metaphorical, and the human tendency to build walls between ourselves.

"Birches" - A contemplation on youth, imagination, and the passage from childhood to adulthood, using the image of bending birch trees as a metaphor.

"Fire and Ice" - A short, powerful poem that considers the possible ways the world might end, either in fire or ice, and what they represent symbolically.

"Acquainted with the Night" - Explores themes of loneliness, alienation, and the darkness within the human soul, set against the backdrop of a nighttime cityscape.

"Out, Out—" - A poignant narrative poem about a young boy's tragic accident while working with a buzz saw, which explores themes of mortality and the fragility of life.

"Nothing Gold Can Stay" - A brief but profound poem that reflects on the fleeting nature of beauty and innocence.

"Design" - Explores the apparent randomness and cruelty of nature through the observation of a spider and a moth caught in a web.

"The Gift Outright" - Written for John F. Kennedy's presidential inauguration, this poem celebrates the American spirit and the idea of a nation forged through struggle and sacrifice.

Style and critical reception

Critic Harold Bloom argued that Frost was one of "the major American poets"

The poet and critic Randall Jarrell often praised Frost's poetry and wrote "Robert Frost, along with Stevens and Eliot, seems to me the greatest of the American poets of this century. Frost's virtues are extraordinary. No other living poet has written so well about the actions of ordinary men; his wonderful dramatic monologues or dramatic scenes come out of a knowledge of people that few poets have had, and they are written in a verse that uses, sometimes with absolute mastery, the rhythms of actual speech". He also praised "Frost's seriousness and honesty", stating that

Frost was particularly skilled at representing a wide range of human experience in his poems.

Jarrell's notable and influential essays on Frost include the essays "Robert Frost's 'Home Burial'" (1962), which consisted of an extended close reading of that particular poem, and "To The Laodiceans" (1952) in which Jarrell defended Frost against critics who had accused Frost of being too "traditional" and out of touch with Modern or Modernist poetry.

In Frost's defense, Jarrell wrote "the regular ways of looking at Frost's poetry are grotesque simplifications, distortions, falsifications—coming to know his poetry well ought to be enough, in itself, to dispel any of them, and to make plain the necessity of finding some other way of talking about his work." And Jarrell's close readings of poems like "Neither Out Too Far Nor In Too Deep" led readers and critics to perceive more of the complexities in Frost's poetry.

In an introduction to Jarrell's book of essays, Brad Leithauser notes that "the 'other' Frost that Jarrell discerned behind the genial, homespun New England rustic—the 'dark' Frost who was desperate, frightened, and brave—has become the Frost we've all learned to recognize, and the little-known poems Jarrell singled out as central to the Frost canon are now to be found in most anthologies". Jarrell lists a selection of the Frost poems he considers the most masterful, including "The Witch of Coös", "Home Burial", "A Servant to Servants", "Directive", "Neither Out Too Far Nor In Too Deep", "Provide, Provide", "Acquainted with the Night", "After Apple Picking", "Mending Wall", "The Most of It", "An Old Man's Winter Night", "To Earthward", "Stopping by Woods on a Snowy Evening", "Spring Pools", "The Lovely Shall Be Choosers", "Design", and "Desert Places".

From "**Birches**"

In The Norton Anthology of Modern Poetry, editors Richard Ellmann and Robert O'Clair compared and contrasted Frost's unique style to the work of the poet Edwin Arlington Robinson since they both frequently used New England settings for their poems. However, they state that Frost's poetry was "less [consciously] literary" and that this was possibly due to the influence of English and Irish writers like Thomas Hardy and W. B. Yeats. They note that Frost's poems "show a successful striving for utter colloquialism" and always try to remain down to earth, while at the same time using traditional forms despite the trend of American poetry towards free verse which Frost famously said was "'like playing tennis without a net.'"

In providing an overview of Frost's style, the Poetry Foundation makes the same point, placing Frost's work "at the crossroads of nineteenth-century American poetry [with regard to his use of traditional forms] and modernism [with his use of idiomatic language and ordinary, everyday subject matter]." They also note that Frost believed that "the self-imposed restrictions of meter in form" was more helpful than harmful because he could focus on the content of his poems instead of concerning himself with creating "innovative" new verse forms.

An earlier 1963 study by the poet James Radcliffe Squires spoke to the distinction of Frost as a poet whose verse soars more for the difficulty and skill by which he attains his final visions, than for the philosophical purity of the visions themselves. "He has written at a time when the choice for the poet seemed to lie among the forms of despair: Science, solipsism, or the religion of the past century ... Frost has refused all of these and in the refusal has long seemed less dramatically committed

than others ... But no, he must be seen as dramatically uncommitted to the single solution ... Insofar as Frost allows to both fact and intuition a bright kingdom, he speaks for many of us. Insofar as he speaks through an amalgam of senses and sure experience so that his poetry seems a nostalgic memory with overtones touching some conceivable future, he speaks better than most of us. That is to say, as a poet must."

The classicist Helen H. Bacon has proposed that Frost's deep knowledge of Greek and Roman classics influenced much of his work. Frost's education at Lawrence High School, Dartmouth, and Harvard "was based mainly on the classics". As examples, she links imagery and action in Frost's early poems "Birches" (1915) and "Wild Grapes" (1920) with Euripides' *Bacchae*. She cites certain motifs, including that of the tree bent down to earth, as evidence of his "very attentive reading of *Bacchae*, almost certainly in Greek". In a later poem, "One More Brevity" (1953), Bacon compares the poetic techniques used by Frost to those of Virgil in the *Aeneid*. She notes that "this sampling of the ways Frost drew on the literature and concepts of the Greek and Roman world at every stage of his life indicates how imbued with it he was".

Themes

In *Contemporary Literary Criticism*, the editors state that "Frost's best work explores fundamental questions of existence, depicting with chilling starkness the loneliness of the individual in an indifferent universe." The critic T. K. Whipple focused on this bleakness in Frost's work, stating that "in much of his work, particularly in *North of Boston*, his harshest book, he emphasizes the dark background of life in rural New England, with its degeneration often sinking into total madness."

In sharp contrast, the founding publisher and editor of *Poetry*, Harriet Monroe, emphasized the folksy New England persona and characters in Frost's work, writing that "perhaps no other poet in our history has put the best of the Yankee spirit into a book so completely." She notes his frequent use of rural settings and farm life, and she likes that in these poems, Frost is most interested in "showing the human reaction to nature's processes." She also notes that while Frost's narrative, character-based poems are often satirical, Frost always has a "sympathetic humor" towards his subjects.

Prizes and Awards

Robert Frost's contributions to literature were widely recognized during his lifetime, with numerous awards and honors bestowed upon him. Some of the most notable awards and recognitions include:

Nominations for the Nobel Prize in Literature: Frost was nominated for the Nobel Prize in Literature a remarkable 31 times, a testament to the high regard in which his work was held internationally.

Poet Laureate of Vermont: Frost was elected as Poet Laureate of Vermont by the Vermont State League of Women's Clubs in June 1922. Despite criticism from some quarters, he received support from fellow writers and poets, including Sarah Cleghorn, who defended his appointment.

3. Memberships in prestigious organizations: Frost was elected to the American Academy of Arts and Sciences in 1931 and the American Philosophical Society in 1937, further cementing his status as a leading literary figure in the United States.

Poet Laureate of Vermont (1961): In July 1961, Frost was named Poet Laureate of Vermont by the state legislature through Joint Resolution R-59 of the Acts of 1961. This recognition honored his significant contributions to Vermont's cultural heritage.

5. Bollingen Prize (1963): Frost was awarded the Bollingen Prize in 1963, acknowledging his outstanding achievements in poetry and his

Pulitzer Prizes: Frost received four Pulitzer Prizes for Poetry during his lifetime, recognizing his exceptional talent and literary contributions: 1924: New Hampshire: A Poem With Notes and Grace Notes

ROBERT FROST'S POETIC ELEMENTS

Imagery: Frost employs vivid and evocative imagery to bring his poems to life, painting detailed pictures of landscapes, seasons, and natural phenomena.

2. Symbolism: Frost uses symbols and metaphors to convey deeper meanings and explore complex themes. His use of symbolism often adds layers of significance to his poetry.

Meter and rhyme: Frost is known for his skillful use of meter and rhyme, employing traditional poetic forms such as blank verse, iambic pentameter, and rhyme schemes to create musicality and rhythm in his poems.

Tone and mood: Frost's poetry exhibits a wide range of tones and moods, from contemplative and meditative to playful and ironic. He adeptly manipulates tone and mood to convey the emotional resonance of his themes.

Narrative voice: Frost often employs a narrative voice in his poetry, drawing readers into his poems through the perspective of a speaker who observes, reflects, or interacts with the world around them.

Diction: Frost's choice of language is precise and economical, with a focus on everyday speech and colloquial expressions. His use of diction adds authenticity and depth to his portrayal of characters and settings.

Theme and subject matter: Frost's poetry explores a wide range of themes and subject matter, including nature, human experience, choice, mortality, and the passage of time. His thematic concerns are often deeply rooted in the New England landscape and rural life.

Irony and ambiguity: Frost frequently employs irony and ambiguity in his poetry, challenging readers to question assumptions and consider multiple interpretations of his poems.

Structure and form: Frost's poems are often carefully structured, with a clear sense of beginning, middle, and end. He also experiments with form, incorporating elements such as dialogue, narrative, and dramatic monologue into his work.

Universality: Despite his focus on rural New England and specific themes, Frost's poetry has a universal appeal that resonates with readers across cultures and generations. His ability to capture the essence of the human experience transcends time and place, making his work enduringly relevant.

Poetic techniques

Robert Frost employed a variety of poetic techniques to convey his themes and ideas effectively. He was known for his use of vivid imagery, employing descriptive language to evoke landscapes and emotions. Frost also utilized symbolism to imbue his poetry with deeper meaning, often drawing on elements of nature to represent broader human experiences.

Additionally, Frost was a master of meter and rhyme, frequently employing traditional poetic forms such as blank verse, rhymed couplets, and iambic pentameter. He skillfully crafted his verse to create musicality and rhythm, enhancing the aesthetic appeal of his poetry.

Another notable technique used by Frost is his use of ambiguity and irony, allowing readers to interpret his works in various ways and uncover hidden layers of meaning. He often employed narrative techniques, such as persona poems and dramatic monologues, to explore different perspectives and voices within his poetry.

Overall, Frost's poetic techniques, including imagery, symbolism, meter, rhyme, ambiguity, and narrative, contributed to the rich complexity and enduring appeal of his poetry.

CHAPTER II

DRAMATIC ELEMENTS IN FROST'S POETRY

Character

Frost's characters encompass a diverse range of personas, from the solitary wanderer to the introspective farmer, each representing different facets of the human condition. For example, in poems like "Stopping by Woods on a Snowy Evening," the traveler symbolizes the allure of escape and contemplation, while in "Mowing," the farmer embodies the dignity of labor and the rhythms of rural life.

One of Frost's notable achievements is his ability to imbue his characters with depth and complexity through sparse yet evocative language. Despite often appearing as archetypes or representatives of broader themes, Frost's characters possess distinct personalities and motivations that resonate with readers. Whether it's the neighbor in "Mending Wall" clinging to tradition or the husband and wife in "Home Burial" struggling to communicate their grief, Frost's characters confront the challenges and dilemmas of existence with authenticity and humanity.

Moreover, Frost's characters frequently engage in dialogue that reveals their inner thoughts, emotions, and conflicts, adding layers of depth and authenticity to his poems. Through their interactions, readers gain insight into the hopes, fears, and aspirations of Frost's characters, fostering empathy and understanding for their struggles and experiences.

While Frost's characters may not always undergo dramatic transformations or arcs typical of traditional drama, they nevertheless serve as vehicles for exploring timeless themes and truths about the human condition. Through his keen observation of character and his mastery of poetic craft, Frost creates characters that resonate with readers across generations, inviting them to reflect on their own lives and experiences in light of the struggles and triumphs of his protagonists.

Her Action

Her Dialogue

Her tension

Conflict

Catharsis

ROBERT FROST'S CHARACTERES AS DRAMATIC PERSONAE

The most important element of a dramatic poem is 'Action' The difference between a dramatic and non-dramatic poem is not simply a matter of form. A poem may be dramatic in form and yet it may not come in the category of a dramatic poem. On the other hand, a particular poem may be a narrative in form and yet it may be a perfect dramatic poem. In this context Lynen's statement is quite enlightening: "The only valid way of distinguishing the dramatic poems is by their primary emphasis on action felt to be happening in the present...The action in the dramatic poems has immediacy – we seem to see the events acted out before us. Where the action has this immediacy, the narrative elements will be clearly secondary; retrospection will give way to a sense of present experience."

I. Plot in Frost's Poetry

A. Definition and Importance

The plot in Frost's poetry often focuses on simple, everyday events that explore deeper emotional and philosophical themes.

B. Examples

1. "The Death of the Hired Man"

Silas returns to the farm of Warren and Mary, looking for a place to die with dignity. Their conversation reveals themes of compassion and duty.

2. "Home Burial"

The plot revolves around a grieving couple's confrontation, highlighting their emotional distance and failure to communicate.

C. Analysis

Frost's plots, while often straightforward, delve deeply into human emotions and relationships, making them compelling and relatable.

II. Setting in Frost's Poetry

A. Role and Significance

Settings in Frost's poetry are crucial as they interact with the characters and themes, often reflecting the characters' internal states.

B. Examples

1. "Stopping by Woods on a Snowy Evening"

- The quiet, snowy woods mirror the speaker's contemplative state and the tension between rest and duty.

2. "After Apple-Picking"

- The orchard represents the speaker's reflection on life's work and accomplishments, symbolizing themes of labor and fulfillment.

C. Analysis

Frost's settings enhance the emotional and philosophical depth of his poems, often symbolizing internal conflicts.

III. Narration in Frost's Poetry

A. Definition and Function

Frost uses various narrative voices, from first-person reflections to dialogues, to shape the reader's engagement with the poem.

B. Examples

1. "The Road Not Taken"

The introspective first-person narration invites readers into the speaker's thoughts on choice and consequence.

2. "Birches"

The reflective voice blends imagery and meditation, creating a tone that explores human desire and reality.

C. Analysis

Narrative voices in Frost's poetry provide insight into characters' thoughts and emotions, enhancing the dramatic action.

IV. The Need for a Choice

A. Definition and Importance

Choices in Frost's poetry often serve as pivotal moments that drive the narrative and reveal character depth.

B. Examples

1. "The Road Not Taken"

The speaker's choice between two paths symbolizes broader themes of decision-making and life's uncertainties.

2. "Mending Wall"

The decision to rebuild the wall reflects themes of boundaries, tradition, and relationships.

C. Analysis

Choices in Frost's poetry highlight individual agency and the complexities of decision-making, adding dramatic tension.

V. Internal and External Action

A. Definition and Function

Internal action refers to characters' thoughts and feelings, while external action involves their physical actions and interactions.

B. Examples

1. "Stopping by Woods on a Snowy Evening"

Internal conflict between rest and duty contrasts with the external action of stopping briefly.

2. "Home Burial"

The wife's internal grief contrasts with the husband's pragmatic external actions, intensifying the drama.

C. Analysis

The interplay between internal and external actions adds psychological complexity to Frost's characters, driving the dramatic action.

VI. Gesture as Action

A. Definition and Significance

Gestures in Frost's poetry often carry significant symbolic weight, revealing deeper meanings and emotions.

B. Examples

1. "The Death of the Hired Man"

Mary's gesture of placing Silas by the fire shows her compassion, contrasting with Warren's initial reluctance.

The act of picking apples symbolizes life's work and accomplishments, adding depth to the speaker's reflection.

Gestures in Frost's poetry enhance the dramatic effect by highlighting the subtleties of human interaction and the weight of simple acts.

Frost employs plot, setting, narration, choices, internal and external actions, and gestures to create dramatic action in his poetry. These elements reveal the intricacies of human experience, making Frost's poetry emotionally and intellectually engaging. Frost's integration of dramatic elements ensures his poetry's lasting impact, inviting readers to reflect on their own lives and experiences.

The Presentation of Opposing Views

The Clash of Temperaments and Views

The Resolution of Conflict

This conflict is often portrayed through the presentation of opposing views or attitudes as in 'Two Tramps in Mud Time' and 'Mending wall'. Sometimes this clash of opposing views is present within the mind of a single person as it is in 'Stopping by Woods on a Snowy Evening', 'The Road Not Taken', 'The Fear' etc. clash of temperaments is shown in poems like 'The Mountain', 'Home Burial', 'The Death of the Hired Man' and 'The Housekeeper'.

Robert Frost, a preeminent American poet of the 20th century, is celebrated for his masterful use of language and his profound exploration of human experience through the lens of rural New England life. Central to much of his work is the theme of conflict, which he presents in various forms—through opposition of views, clashes of temperament, and the resolution of these conflicts. This study will delve into these dimensions of conflict in Frost's poetry, examining how they contribute to the richness and depth of his work.

Presentation of Opposing Views

Frost's poetry frequently begins with the presentation of opposing views. This allows him to explore multiple perspectives and highlight the complexity of human experiences and relationships.

"Mending Wall"

"Mending Wall" is perhaps one of Frost's most famous explorations of opposing views. The poem centers on the annual tradition of repairing a stone wall that separates the speaker's property from his neighbor's.

Opposition of Views: The speaker questions the need for the wall, noting that “Something there is that doesn’t love a wall,” implying that nature itself seeks to break down barriers. In contrast, the neighbor insists, “Good fences make good neighbors,” reflecting a more conservative, tradition-bound perspective.

Symbolism and Conflict: The wall symbolizes the boundaries people erect to maintain their privacy and individuality. The speaker's view represents a more progressive outlook, suggesting that such barriers are unnecessary and contrary to the natural order. The neighbor’s view, on the other hand, emphasizes the importance of tradition and boundaries for maintaining harmonious relationships.

The opposition in "Mending Wall" highlights a fundamental human conflict between change and tradition. The speaker's curiosity and willingness to question established norms clash with the neighbor's adherence to conventional wisdom. This tension reflects broader societal conflicts about progress and preservation, individuality, and community.

"The Death of the Hired Man"

In "The Death of the Hired Man," Frost presents a domestic conflict that reveals differing views on duty, responsibility, and compassion.

Opposition of Views: Warren and Mary, a husband and wife, have contrasting views on how to deal with Silas, an old farmhand who has returned to their home. Warren sees Silas as unreliable and undeserving of their help, focusing on his past failures and practical concerns. Mary, however, believes in offering compassion and a dignified end, emphasizing his humanity and their moral responsibility.

Character Dynamics: Warren's practical, no-nonsense attitude conflicts with Mary’s nurturing and empathetic nature. This opposition is not merely a difference in opinion but a deeper clash of worldviews regarding what constitutes duty and kindness.

The poem explores the complexity of human relationships and moral obligations. Warren’s pragmatic approach is juxtaposed with Mary’s compassionate stance, revealing the multifaceted nature of duty and empathy. This conflict underscores the

tensions between practicality and morality, and how these values shape our interactions and decisions.

"The Road Not Taken"

"The Road Not Taken" is a reflection on choices and their consequences, presenting an internal conflict between differing paths in life.

Opposition of Views: The speaker reflects on the choice between two diverging paths, symbolizing the conflict of decisions we face in life. The opposing views are internal, representing the speaker's contemplation of the consequences of each choice and the inherent uncertainty in deciding which path to take.

Symbolism: The roads symbolize life's choices, and the decision to take one path over another reflects the broader human experience of making choices with uncertain outcomes. The speaker's reflection on the road "less traveled by" captures the tension between following conventional wisdom and forging one's unique path.

The poem highlights the inevitable conflict that arises from decision-making and the human tendency to reflect on the paths not taken. This internal opposition emphasizes the themes of choice, regret, and the unpredictable nature of life. The speaker's contemplation reveals the profound impact of our decisions and the inherent conflict in choosing one path over another.

2. Clash of Temperament and Views

Beyond the presentation of opposing views, Frost's poetry often delves into the clash of temperaments and views, creating dramatic tension and revealing the characters' psychological depths.

"Home Burial"

"Home Burial" is a powerful exploration of grief and the clash of temperaments between a husband and wife who have lost their child.

Clash of Temperaments: Amy, the wife, is emotionally expressive and struggles to understand her husband's stoic demeanor. She accuses him of indifference, unable to comprehend his way of processing grief. The husband, on the other hand, feels misunderstood and frustrated by Amy's outward display of sorrow, which he perceives as a rejection of his own pain.

Dialogue and Conflict: The intense dialogue between Amy and her husband reveals the deep emotional chasm between them. Their inability to communicate their grief effectively exacerbates the conflict, highlighting their differing ways of coping with loss.

The poem captures the profound impact of grief on relationships and the challenges of communication and empathy. The clash of temperaments between Amy and her husband illustrates the isolation that can arise within intimate relationships when individuals fail to understand and support each other's emotional needs. This conflict underscores the complexities of human emotions and the difficulty of navigating shared sorrow.

"Fire and Ice"

"Fire and Ice," though brief, encapsulates a clash of views about the end of the world, using metaphorical elements to explore human emotions.

Clash of Views: The poem presents two opposing views about the apocalypse—some believe it will end in fire (symbolizing desire) and others in ice (symbolizing hatred). This metaphorical clash reflects the destructive potential of human emotions.

Symbolism and Conflict: Fire and ice serve as metaphors for passionate desire and cold indifference, respectively. The conflict between these elements symbolizes the broader human struggle between intense emotions and detachment, both of which can lead to catastrophic outcomes.

The poem's exploration of extreme emotions as agents of destruction serves as a commentary on human nature. The contrasting elements of fire and ice symbolize

the internal conflicts of passion versus rationality, and love versus hatred. This dichotomy underscores the destructive capacity inherent in both unchecked desire and indifference, suggesting a broader philosophical conflict about the forces that drive human behavior.

"The Death of the Hired Man"

The clash of temperaments is also evident in "The Death of the Hired Man," where Warren and Mary's differing views on Silas reflect deeper personality differences.

Clash of Temperaments: Warren's practical and hardened outlook contrasts with Mary's nurturing and empathetic nature. This clash drives the narrative, revealing the complexity of their relationship and their differing values.

Character Dynamics: The interplay between Warren's practicality and Mary's compassion highlights the broader societal conflict between duty and empathy. Their contrasting temperaments bring depth to the exploration of themes like responsibility, humanity, and the moral implications of their actions.

The poem illustrates the tension between practicality and morality. Warren's focus on the practical implications of Silas's return contrasts with Mary's emotional and moral considerations. This clash of temperaments underscores the multifaceted nature of human relationships and the challenges of balancing duty with compassion.

"Two Tramps in Mud Time"

"Two Tramps in Mud Time" presents a conflict between personal fulfillment and social responsibility, exploring the clash between the speaker's joy in chopping wood and the tramps' need for work.

Clash of Temperaments: The speaker takes pleasure in his work, finding personal satisfaction and fulfillment in chopping wood. The tramps, on the other hand, are driven by necessity and survival, seeking employment to sustain themselves.

Moral Dilemma: The conflict between the speaker's desire to continue his enjoyable task and the tramps' need for employment creates a moral dilemma. This clash highlights the tension between individual desires and collective needs.

The poem explores the ethical considerations of privilege and social responsibility. The speaker's joy in his work contrasts with the tramps' desperate need for survival, illustrating the broader conflict between personal fulfillment and the obligation to support those in need. This moral dilemma emphasizes the complexity of balancing self-interest with social conscience.

3. Resolution of Conflict

Frost's poetry often addresses the resolution of conflicts, offering insights into reconciliation, compromise, and the acceptance of ambiguity.

"Mending Wall"

The resolution in "Mending Wall" is ambiguous, reflecting the complexities of human relationships and societal traditions.

Ambiguous Resolution: Despite the speaker's doubts and questioning of the wall's necessity, the neighbors continue to rebuild it. This suggests a compromise between maintaining tradition and questioning its relevance.

Symbolism: The act of mending the wall becomes a ritual that maintains a sense of order and neighborly boundaries. The resolution reflects the tension between personal beliefs and social customs, suggesting that some conflicts may remain unresolved yet manageable through mutual respect.

The poem's conclusion highlights the complexity of human relationships and the persistence of traditions. The ambiguous resolution emphasizes the idea that while personal beliefs may conflict with societal norms, coexistence and mutual respect are possible through compromise and understanding.

"The Death of the Hired Man"

The resolution in "The Death of the Hired Man" reflects a shift in perspective and the acceptance of moral responsibility.

Resolution: Warren ultimately accepts Silas's return and provides him a place to die, recognizing the need for compassion and human dignity. This change signifies a broader understanding of moral responsibility and the value of human connections.

Character Development: Warren's acceptance of Silas represents a transformation in his character, from a pragmatic and hardened individual to one who acknowledges the importance of empathy and compassion.

Robert Frost's poetry masterfully explores dramatic conflict through the presentation of opposing views, clashes of temperament, and resolutions that often embrace ambiguity. By delving into the complexities of human experience, Frost's work resonates with readers, offering profound insights into the nature of conflict, communication, and human relationships. His ability to capture the subtle nuances of emotional and moral dilemmas solidifies his reputation as a poet who deeply understands the human condition.

Dramatic Dialogue in Frost's Poetry

Robert Frost, a quintessential American poet, masterfully employs dramatic dialogue in his poetry to explore complex human relationships and emotions. His use of everyday conversation, arguments, debates, asides, and soliloquies brings his characters to life, allowing readers to engage deeply with their experiences. This

comprehensive study examines the different facets of dramatic dialogue in Frost's poetry, focusing on how these elements enhance the emotional and thematic depth of his work.

Everyday Conversation: The Voices of Men and Women

One of the hallmarks of Frost's poetry is his ability to capture the natural rhythms and cadences of everyday speech. His characters often engage in conversations that reflect the nuances of real-life interactions, giving voice to the men and women of rural New England. Through these dialogues, Frost explores themes of love, loss, duty, and human connection.

"The Death of the Hired Man"

"The Death of the Hired Man" features a poignant conversation between Warren and Mary, a married couple discussing the return of their old farmhand, Silas. The dialogue reveals their contrasting perspectives and emotional responses.

1. Characterization through Everyday Speech: The authenticity of the dialogue in "The Death of the Hired Man" lies in its simplicity and naturalness. Warren's practical concerns are evident in his straightforward speech, while Mary's empathy and compassion are conveyed through her gentle and nurturing tone.

-**Warren:** "What help he is there's no depending on. Off he goes always when I need him most."

- **Mary:** "He has come home to die: You needn't be afraid he'll leave you this time."

2. Emotional Resonance: The everyday conversation between Warren and Mary allows Frost to delve into deeper themes of human dignity, compassion, and moral duty. Mary's insistence on providing Silas with a place to die with dignity highlights her empathetic nature, contrasting with Warren's pragmatic view.

3. Natural Cadence: The dialogue's natural cadence and colloquial language ground the poem in a realistic setting, making the characters' experiences relatable and their emotions palpable.

"Home Burial"

In "Home Burial," Frost captures the raw emotion and tension between a grieving husband and wife. The dialogue in this poem is a powerful example of how everyday conversation can reveal profound emotional and psychological depths.

1. Expressing Grief and Miscommunication: The husband and wife's conversation reflects their inability to communicate their grief effectively. Amy's dialogue is charged with emotion and accusation, while her husband's responses are more measured and defensive.

- **Amy:** "You can't because you don't know how to speak. If you had any feelings, you that dug With your own hand how could you? his little grave."

- **Husband:** "I can't talk to you. You don't understand. You think you can only see it in my face."

2. Revealing Inner Turmoil: Through their everyday conversation, Frost exposes the inner turmoil of both characters. Amy's dialogue reveals her frustration and sorrow, while her husband's words reflect his struggle to understand and express his own grief.

3. Building Tension: The natural flow of the conversation builds tension and highlights the emotional distance between the couple. The dialogue's authenticity makes their pain and miscommunication all the more poignant.

"Mending Wall"

"Mending Wall" presents a dialogue between two neighbors as they repair a wall that divides their properties. The poem uses everyday conversation to explore broader themes of tradition and boundaries.

1. Philosophical Debate in Everyday Language: The conversation between the speaker and his neighbor is rooted in everyday language, yet it touches on philosophical questions about the nature of boundaries and human relationships.

-Speaker: "Before I built a wall I'd ask to know What I was walling in or walling out, And to whom I was like to give offense."

-Neighbor: "Good fences make good neighbors."

2. Contrasting Perspectives: The dialogue reflects the contrasting perspectives of the two men. The speaker's questioning attitude and the neighbor's adherence to tradition create a subtle yet significant tension.

3. Symbolism in Conversation: The everyday conversation symbolizes the broader societal tension between progress and tradition. The dialogue's simplicity belies its deeper philosophical implications.

Argument and Debate with Self and Other

Frost often uses dialogue to depict arguments and debates, both between characters and within the minds of his speakers. These dialogues reveal the complexities of human thought and the struggle to reconcile conflicting emotions and ideas.

"The Road Not Taken"

While "The Road Not Taken" is primarily a monologue, it can be read as a dialogue between the speaker and his inner self. The poem explores the theme of choice and the human tendency to question and debate one's decisions.

1. Internal Debate: The speaker's internal dialogue reflects his struggle to come to terms with his choice. He imagines what could have been, creating a sense of ongoing debate within himself.

-Speaker: "Two roads diverged in a yellow wood, / And sorry I could not travel both / And be one traveler, long I stood / And looked down one as far as I could."

2. Expression of Regret and Acceptance: The internal debate captures the speaker's regret and acceptance, highlighting the complexity of human emotions when faced with irreversible choices.

3. Philosophical Reflection: The poem's internal dialogue is a philosophical reflection on the nature of choice and the inevitability of wondering about the road not taken.

"Birches"

In "Birches," Frost uses the speaker's internal debate to explore themes of reality and imagination. The dialogue within the speaker's mind reflects his desire to escape the hardships of life and return to a simpler, more innocent time.

1. Conflict Between Reality and Imagination: The speaker's internal dialogue captures the conflict between the harsh realities of life and the comforting allure of imagination.

-Speaker: "When I see birches bend to left and right / Across the lines of straighter darker trees, / I like to think some boy's been swinging them."

2. Yearning for Escape: The internal debate reveals the speaker's yearning to escape the burdens of adulthood and return to the carefree days of youth. The dialogue within his mind reflects a deeper existential longing.

3. Resolution Through Reflection: The poem's internal dialogue concludes with the speaker acknowledging the need to balance reality and imagination, finding solace in the idea of temporary escape through his memories and imagination.

"The Death of the Hired Man"

The argument between Warren and Mary in "The Death of the Hired Man" serves as a debate about duty, compassion, and human dignity. Their dialogue reflects the broader ethical and philosophical questions that underpin their conflict.

1. Ethical Debate: The dialogue between Warren and Mary is an ethical debate about the responsibilities they owe to Silas. Warren's practicality clashes with Mary's compassion, creating a dynamic and thought-provoking argument.

2. Exploring Moral Duty: Through their debate, Frost explores the theme of moral duty. Mary's insistence on providing Silas with a place to die with dignity highlights the importance of empathy and compassion in human relationships.

3. Resolution Through Dialogue: The resolution of the poem comes through the dialogue, as Warren ultimately agrees to let Silas stay, influenced by Mary's arguments. This resolution underscores the power of dialogue to effect change and understanding.

Asides and Soliloquies

In addition to everyday conversation and debates, Frost employs asides and soliloquies to provide deeper insight into his characters' thoughts and emotions. These elements of dramatic dialogue allow Frost to explore the inner lives of his characters in greater detail.

"Stopping by Woods on a Snowy Evening"

"Stopping by Woods on a Snowy Evening" features a soliloquy that captures the speaker's moment of introspection and contemplation. The poem's quiet, reflective tone is enhanced by the use of soliloquy.

1. Inner Reflection: The soliloquy reveals the speaker's inner thoughts as he pauses to contemplate the beauty of the woods and the pull of his obligations.

-Speaker: "The woods are lovely, dark and deep, / But I have promises to keep, / And miles to go before I sleep."

2. Existential Contemplation: The soliloquy captures the speaker's existential contemplation, reflecting on the tension between the desire for rest and the need to fulfill responsibilities.

3. Emotional Resonance: The use of soliloquy creates an intimate connection between the speaker and the reader, allowing for a deeper emotional resonance as the speaker's inner conflict is laid bare.

"After Apple-Picking"

In "After Apple-Picking," Frost uses soliloquy to convey the speaker's exhaustion and reflection on life's labor and rewards. The poem's reflective tone is enhanced by the soliloquy, which reveals the speaker's inner thoughts and feelings.

1. Reflective Soliloquy: The soliloquy captures the speaker's physical and emotional exhaustion after a day of apple-picking, as well as his contemplation of the broader implications of his labor.

- **Speaker:** "For I have had too much / Of apple-picking: I am overtired / Of the great harvest I myself desired."

2. Existential Themes: The soliloquy explores existential themes of work, fulfillment, and the passage of time. The speaker's reflections on his day's labor serve as a metaphor for the broader human experience.

Emotional Depth

: The soliloquy allows Frost to delve into the speaker's emotions, creating a rich, introspective narrative that resonates with readers on a personal level.

Robert Frost, renowned for his evocative poetry capturing the essence of rural New England life, masterfully infuses his works with dramatic elements that resonate with readers on multiple levels. Through a combination of lyric and narrative poems, Frost creates a rich tapestry of inner and outer drama, exploring themes of human experience, nature, and the human condition. This critical analysis delves into

Frost's use of dramatic conclusion in his poetry, examining how lyric poems serve as inner dramas and narrative poems as relatable mini-dramas, each contributing to the overarching narrative of Frost's literary legacy.

To sum up, it would be in order to recall in brief what has already been stated in the preceding chapters regarding the presence of dramatic elements in the poetry of Robert Frost.

Chapter I shows that Robert Frost's life was full of contradictions and conflict, fatigue and failures, adulations and accusations; but perhaps these are the steps of the ladder which take one to the top. Higher the tree, deeper are its roots. In every phase and field of life, Robert Frost had to face uncertainties, disappointment and distress. But he was untiring and constantly continued his journey without accepting defeat as he knew that he had to cover a long distance before the final step; "miles to go before I sleep," as he put it.

Chapter II deals with various dramatic elements, that is, character, action, dialogue, tension, conflict and catharsis. These are important dramatic elements and have been discussed separately and in relation to each other.

Chapters III, IV, V, and VI, illustrate with the help of examples from Frost's various narrative poems as also some lyric poems how the above mentioned dramatic elements are present in Frost's poetry.

Lyric Poems as Inner Drama

In Frost's lyric poems, the dramatic conclusion often lies in the internal journey of the speaker, as they grapple with existential questions, personal dilemmas, and moments of self-discovery. These poems offer glimpses into the inner workings of the human psyche, inviting readers to explore the complexities of human emotion and experience.

"Stopping by Woods on a Snowy Evening"

"Stopping by Woods on a Snowy Evening" is a quintessential example of Frost's lyric poetry, where the dramatic conclusion unfolds within the speaker's

contemplative journey through the snowy woods. The poem's concluding lines resonate with a sense of quiet resolve and existential contemplation.

1. Inner Conflict and Resolution: Throughout the poem, the speaker wrestles with the temptation to linger in the tranquil beauty of the woods versus the obligations awaiting him. The concluding lines—"But I have promises to keep, / And miles to go before I sleep"—underscore the speaker's acknowledgment of duty and responsibility, marking a moment of inner resolve and self-awareness.

2. Existential Themes: The dramatic conclusion of "Stopping by Woods on a Snowy Evening" encapsulates broader existential themes of duty, mortality, and the passage of time. The speaker's decision to continue on his journey symbolizes the universal human experience of confronting life's responsibilities and obligations.

3. Emotional Resonance: Frost's evocative language and imagery evoke a sense of quiet contemplation and introspection, inviting readers to reflect on their own inner conflicts and moral dilemmas. The poem's dramatic conclusion resonates with readers on a deeply personal level, prompting introspection and self-examination.

"The Road Not Taken"

Another iconic lyric poem by Frost, "The Road Not Taken," explores themes of choice, regret, and self-discovery. The poem's dramatic conclusion lies in the speaker's contemplation of the path not taken and the significance of personal choices.

1. Reflection on Choices: Throughout the poem, the speaker reflects on the diverging paths before him, ultimately choosing the less traveled one. The concluding lines—"I took the one less traveled by, / And that has made all the difference"—highlight the speaker's recognition of the profound impact of his choice, marking a moment of personal revelation and self-affirmation.

2. Regret and Acceptance: The dramatic conclusion of "The Road Not Taken" resonates with themes of regret and acceptance, as the speaker grapples with the consequences of his decision. The ambiguity of the phrase "that has made all the difference" invites multiple interpretations, reflecting the complexity of human

experience and the uncertainty of life's outcomes.

3. Universal Themes: Frost's exploration of choice and individual agency in "The Road Not Taken" speaks to universal truths about human nature and the human condition. The poem's dramatic conclusion prompts readers to reflect on their own life choices and the roads they have taken, inviting introspection and self-examination.

Narrative Poems as Relatable Mini-Dramas

In Frost's narrative poems, the dramatic conclusion unfolds within the context of relatable human experiences and interactions. These poems often feature vivid characters, engaging dialogue, and compelling storylines, inviting readers to immerse themselves in the drama of everyday life in rural New England.

"The Death of the Hired Man" is a poignant narrative poem that explores themes of loyalty, compassion, and human connection. The dramatic conclusion of the poem lies in the resolution of the conflict between Warren and Mary, as they grapple with the impending death of their former farmhand, Silas.

1. Conflict and Resolution: Throughout the poem, Warren and Mary engage in a heated debate about the value of offering Silas a place to die with dignity. The dramatic conclusion comes when Warren relents and agrees to let Silas stay, marking a moment of reconciliation and empathy between the characters.

2. Exploration of Human Relationships: Frost's portrayal of the relationship between Warren and Mary highlights the complexities of human emotions and the bonds that connect us to one another. The dramatic conclusion of "The Death of the Hired Man" underscores the power of compassion and understanding in overcoming

differences and finding common ground.

3. Resonance with Readers: The relatable nature of the characters and the universal themes explored in "The Death of the Hired Man" resonate with readers on a deeply emotional level. The poem's dramatic conclusion prompts reflection on the nature of human relationships and the importance of empathy and compassion in navigating life's challenges.

"Home Burial" is another narrative poem by Frost that delves into the complexities of grief, communication, and marital discord. The dramatic conclusion of the poem lies in the emotional climax between the husband and wife as they confront their shared tragedy and struggle to connect with one another.

1. Emotional Intensity: Throughout the poem, the husband and wife engage in a tense and emotionally charged exchange about the death of their child. The dramatic conclusion comes when the wife accuses her husband of emotional detachment, leading to a moment of profound catharsis and vulnerability.

2. Exploration of Grief and Communication: Frost's portrayal of grief and communication in "Home Burial" highlights the difficulty of expressing emotions and connecting with loved ones in times of crisis. The dramatic conclusion underscores the emotional toll of unresolved conflicts and the importance of empathy and understanding in fostering meaningful connections.

3. Personal Reflection: The emotional depth and raw honesty of "Home Burial" invite readers to reflect on their own experiences with grief, loss, and interpersonal relationships. The poem's dramatic conclusion prompts introspection and self-examination, encouraging empathy and compassion towards others in times of need.

The Enduring Impact of Frost's Dramatic Conclusions

Frost's ability to infuse his poetry with dramatic elements, whether through inner drama in lyric poems or narrative resolution in mini-dramas, underscores his profound understanding of human nature. His work continues to captivate and inspire readers, inviting them to engage with the complexities of life, love, loss, and human connection.

1. Literary Legacy: Frost's poetic legacy is marked by his skillful use of dramatic conclusions to explore the depths of the human condition. His evocative language, compelling characters, and profound themes make his poetry timeless, continuing to resonate with readers across generations.

2. Reader Engagement: The dramatic conclusions in Frost's poetry not only provide closure to the narratives but also leave readers with lingering questions and reflections. This engagement with the reader's own experiences and emotions is a testament to Frost's mastery as a poet.

3. Universal Appeal: The themes and emotions explored in Frost's poetry are universal, making his work accessible and meaningful to a wide audience. Whether through the quiet introspection of a lyric poem or the engaging narrative of a mini-drama, Frost's poetry speaks to the shared human experience.

In conclusion, Robert Frost's poetry, with its dramatic conclusions in both lyric and narrative forms, offers a profound exploration of human emotions and experiences. His ability to capture the inner and outer dramas of life makes his work a rich tapestry of insight and reflection, inviting readers to delve deeply into the complexities of the human condition. Frost's enduring appeal lies in his masterful use of dramatic elements to create poetry that is both thought-provoking and deeply resonant, solidifying his place as one of the greatest poets in American literature.

Robert Frost's poetry is a testament to his profound understanding of the human condition and his ability to capture the drama of everyday life with nuance and depth. Through a combination of lyric and narrative poems, Frost explores themes of choice, regret, grief, and human connection, inviting readers to engage with the complexities of human experience.

In Frost's lyric poems, such as "Stopping by Woods on a Snowy Evening" and "The Road Not Taken," the dramatic conclusion unfolds within the inner landscape of the speaker's mind, as they grapple with existential questions and moments of self-discovery. These poems resonate with readers on a deeply personal level, prompting reflection on the choices we make and the paths we take in life.

In Frost's narrative poems, such as "The Death of the Hired Man" and "Home Burial," the dramatic conclusion emerges from the interactions between vivid characters and the resolution of conflicts and tensions. These poems offer glimpses into the complexities of human relationships and emotions, inviting readers to empathize with the struggles and triumphs of the characters.

Overall, Frost's use of dramatic conclusion in his poetry adds depth, resonance, and emotional complexity to the overarching narrative of his work, enriching our understanding of the human experience and the intricate dynamics of human relationships. Whether through the inner dramas of lyric poetry or the relatable mini-dramas of narrative verse, Frost invites readers to explore the depths of their own emotions and experiences, prompting introspection and self-reflection.

Through his mastery of language, imagery, and narrative technique, Frost creates a vivid and immersive world that resonates with readers across generations. His ability to capture the universal themes of love, loss, hope, and despair speaks to the enduring power of poetry as a medium for exploring the complexities of the human condition.

In conclusion, Robert Frost's poetry continues to captivate and inspire readers with its profound insights, timeless themes, and masterful storytelling. By infusing his works with dramatic conclusion, Frost invites us to embark on a journey of self-discovery and understanding, reminding us of the enduring power of literature to illuminate the depths of the human soul.

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